

Lesson 104: SAFETY PLAYS

1. VOLUNTARY LOSS

of a trick to secure
the contract



★ 2. GOLDEN RULE

“If you need **N** tricks,
play for **N**,
not for **N+1**”



THINK SAFE!

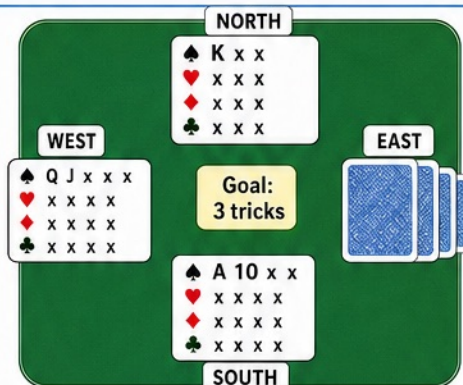
Avoid disaster.
Make your
contract.

3 EXAMPLE 1

A10xx opposite Kxx
(8 cards, goal 3 tricks)

SAFETY PLAY:

- Play small towards the 10.
- If West covers with J or Q, win with K.
- If not covered, insert 10.
- Lose **max 1** trick against QJxxx in West.



HOW IT WORKS

- 1 South plays a small spade towards 10.
10 ← small
 - 2 If West covers with J or Q, win with K.
K ← Q or J
 - 3 If not covered, insert 10 and win the trick.
10 → small
- Lose **max 1** trick
against QJxxx in West.

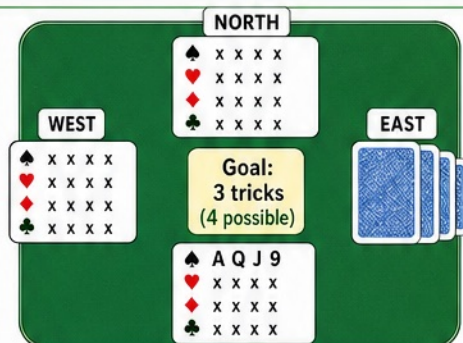
4 EXAMPLE 2

AQJ9 opposite xxxx
(8 cards, goal 3 tricks,
4 possible)

- Simple finesse = 50%
for 4 tricks.

SAFETY PLAY for 3 sure:

- Cash Ace.
- Then play small towards Q.
- Lose **max 1**.



HOW IT WORKS

- 1 Cash the Ace.
A → win
 - 2 Play a small spade
towards Q.
Q ← small
 - 3 If West has Q, you win.
If not, you lose **max 1**.
- You make **3** sure.
4 tricks are possible.

5 EXAMPLE 3

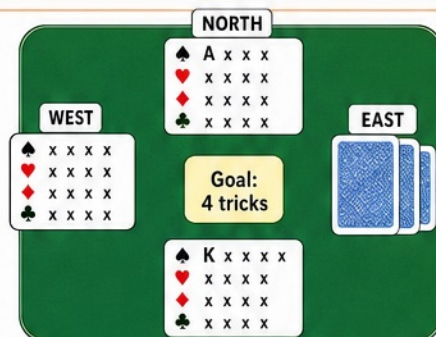
Kxxxx opposite Axxx
(9 cards, goal 4 tricks)

NATURAL LINE:

- Ace, King, small.
- Works if 3-1.
- **Risk** if 4-0.

SAFETY PLAY:

- Play small from dummy.
- Delay inserting the honor.
- Works against 4-0.



HOW IT WORKS

NATURAL LINE (RISKY):

- A → K → small
Works if 3-1.
Risk if West has all 4.

SAFETY PLAY (SAFER):

- small → small → then insert honor
Delay the honor.
This works against 4-0.

Make **4** tricks safely.

DECISION DIAGRAM



MOTTO

The **SAFETY PLAY**
pays a small premium
to **avoid disaster!**